

F LINE

A metaphor for moving 2 miles in New York City

FA 2025 Visual AI Studio

Assignment 04: Kitsch and Camp

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1. Concept Overview

F LINE is a chaotic, intentionally frustrating platformer that acts as a metaphor for commuting in New York City... specifically, the painful journey from Brooklyn to Manhattan on the subway.

What looks like a small map turns into a nightmare of traps, timing, and memorization, a direct reflection of how 2 miles can take 45 minutes in real life. The game constantly works against the player, forcing them to adapt, memorize the layout, and survive the unpredictable hell of city transit.

2. Game Premise

You're just trying to make it to a party.

But this is New York.

So nothing works, nothing is fair, and even your own platforms betray you.

3. Gameplay

Core Mechanics

- **Genre:** Rage-bait 2D platformer
- **Mode:** Local 2-player co-op (WASD + Arrow keys)
- **Goal:** Reach the "party" at the end of the level

Obstacles

- Platforms that run away from you
 - Spooky ghosts
 - Spikes that rise when you try to jump over them
 - Invisible traps and false affordances
 - No checkpoints, no mercy
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4. Aesthetic Style

Kitsch on purpose. The game uses janky visuals, clashing colors, and mismatched sprites to lean into an intentionally broken look. Characters don't match. Platforms don't behave. It's designed to feel unfinished, hacked together, and oddly charming, like a bootleg arcade game you found in the back of a bodega.

Visual Elements

- Pixel art and tilemaps that don't quite line up
 - Bold colors, flat shading
 - Goofy characters: a pink blob and an owl-headed man
 - Screen shake, screen text, and loud effects that overload your senses (plan to add)
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5. Sound Design

Music

High-energy, overstimulating hyperpop, the kind of stuff you might listen to while trying to hype yourself up for a night out or distract yourself on a delayed train.

6. Metaphor & Design Philosophy

F LINE is more than a platformer — it's a symbolic commute simulator.

- The map is small but feels long —> just like NYC travel
- Traps appear randomly — just like MTA delays
- Platforms betray you — just like planned service changes
- You memorize the fastest path over time — just like planning a route to avoid sketchy transfers or ghost trains

The game forces you to adapt, suffer, and eventually master the level through brute repetition, just like living here does.

7. Death & Progression

- A death tracker counts how many times you've failed- it is fun to see how much you suffered to reach the party
 - The more you die, the more you learn the layout and how the game is trying to screw you over
 - It's funny, frustrating, and rewarding in a way that feels uniquely New York
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8. Multiplayer: Shared Pain

Why suffer alone?

F LINE supports two players on one keyboard→ because failing is funnier with a friend.

Controls

- **Player 1:** Arrow keys + Enter
- **Player 2:** WASD + Space

Each player controls a different weird little guy → and if one of you dies, you both restart.

9. Technical Features

Systems

- Tween-based platform movement
- Dynamic Universal Trap adjustability in Inspector
- Collision detection via Area2D nodes
- Reusable KillZone system
- Custom GameManager that tracks:
 - Score (collectibles)
 - Total deaths (persistent)
- Dynamic camera that follows both players
- Designed for replay and speedrunning once memorized

Implementation Details

- Spikes, ghosts, and moving platforms are all scripted to troll the player
 - Killzones use a shared script to track death and restart the level
 - Deaths are counted globally using a game manager, displayed in the UI
 - Players start to build mental maps over time, avoiding "sus" platforms or death traps
 - Platforms can be configured to move vertically or sideways using a per-instance flag
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10. Why Kitsch?

It's messy.

It's janky.

It's over-the-top.

And that's the point.

The whole thing feels like a busted carnival ride that somehow still works. The platforming is slightly unfair. The visuals are too loud. But all of it leans into a DIY, chaotic energy that mirrors the chaos of trying to live and move through NYC.

11. Final Thoughts

F LINE is my love-hate letter to the F train.

It's goofy. It's glitchy. It wants you to lose.

And when you finally win, it'll be by the skin of your teeth.